Delegate Background Guide

COLD WAR

COLD WAR HISTORICAL CRISIS COMMITTEE

Evaluating Diplomatic Solutions to the Cuban Missile Crisis

BACKGROUND GUIDE

Prepared for delegates | MEA

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Letter from the Dais

Honourable Delegates,

Welcome to the Cold War historical crisis committee. In October 1962, the discovery of Soviet nuclear missile sites in Cuba brought the United States and the Soviet Union into a confrontation that risked nuclear war. Decisions were made under uncertainty, time pressure, domestic political constraints, and the possibility that a single miscalculation could trigger catastrophic escalation.

This committee challenges you to evaluate diplomacy as it unfolds. Delegates should understand the security concerns of the United States, the Soviet Union, and Cuba, while considering the wider strategic context: the failed Bay of Pigs invasion, missile deployments in Turkey, alliance commitments, and the roles of the United Nations and the Organization of American States.

The objective is not to judge historical actors with hindsight alone. It is to develop credible diplomatic options, understand the trade-offs, and consider verification, communication, and de-escalation under crisis conditions.

Sincerely,
The Dais

Introduction to the Cold War Committee

A historical crisis committee simulates decision-making during a defined period in the past. Unlike a standard policy committee, delegates may represent particular leaders, advisers, governments, or institutions and respond to evolving events. The exact powers, roles, and crisis mechanics depend on the conference's rules of procedure, so delegates should follow the official committee brief.

The Cuban Missile Crisis took place during the Cold War rivalry between the United States and the Soviet Union. Cuba, led by Fidel Castro, was central to the crisis rather than merely a location. Diplomatic options must account for sovereignty, security, credibility, alliance politics, and the danger of nuclear escalation. Historical sources show that direct messages, back-channel contacts, public statements, military pressure, and multilateral diplomacy all played roles.

Introduction to the Agenda

In the summer of 1962, the Soviet Union and Cuba reached a secret agreement to deploy Soviet nuclear missiles in Cuba, partly to deter another U.S. invasion. U.S. reconnaissance photographs taken on 14 October revealed missile sites under construction. President John F. Kennedy and his advisers considered several options, including an air strike, an invasion, diplomatic pressure, and a naval quarantine.

On 22 October, Kennedy announced the quarantine and demanded the removal of offensive weapons. U.S. forces moved to a heightened state of readiness. Over the following days, messages and proposals passed between Washington and Moscow, while public rhetoric and military activity raised the risk of accidental escalation. On 27 October, often called "Black Saturday," the crisis intensified after a U.S. U-2 aircraft was shot down over Cuba, and Soviet and U.S. communications remained difficult. On 28 October, Khrushchev publicly agreed to dismantle and remove the missiles in exchange for a U.S. pledge not to invade Cuba. A separate, secret understanding concerned the U.S. Jupiter missiles in Turkey, which were later removed.

> **The historical debate is not whether diplomacy mattered, because it did. It is which combination of public pressure, private concessions, verification, and communication made a peaceful outcome possible, and what alternatives might have reduced the risk further.**

Key Terms

TERM	DEFINITION
Cuban Missile Crisis	The October 1962 confrontation over Soviet nuclear missile deployments in Cuba.

TERM	DEFINITION
Quarantine	The U.S. term for a naval interception measure, chosen instead of the word “blockade,” which carried stronger implications of a state of war.
Deterrence	Preventing an action by threatening consequences that make it too costly.
Back-channel diplomacy	Private communication outside formal public diplomatic channels.
ExComm	The Executive Committee of the U.S. National Security Council, which advised Kennedy during the crisis.
DEFCON	The U.S. military’s defense readiness condition system.
Jupiter missiles	U.S. intermediate-range ballistic missiles deployed in Turkey and Italy during the early 1960s.
Verification	Methods used to confirm that an agreement is being implemented.
De-escalation	Steps that reduce immediate tension and the risk of conflict.

Key Issues

1. Security dilemmas and deterrence

The United States viewed Soviet nuclear missiles in Cuba as a direct threat; the Soviet Union viewed U.S. strategic superiority and nearby deployments as security concerns. Cuba feared another U.S. invasion. A durable solution had to address all of these perceptions.

2. Quarantine versus air strike or invasion

A quarantine applied pressure while leaving time for diplomacy, but it also risked a confrontation at sea. An air strike or invasion might have triggered Soviet retaliation and widened the war.

3. Public credibility and private compromise

Leaders faced domestic and alliance pressures. Publicly humiliating an opponent could make compromise harder, while secret concessions could create political controversy.

4. The role of Cuba

Cuba’s sovereignty and security interests were not identical to those of the superpowers. A settlement negotiated only between Washington and Moscow could leave Havana feeling excluded or insecure.

5. Communication failures and accidental escalation

Messages were delayed, ambiguous, or competing. Military incidents, including the shooting down of a U.S. U-2 aircraft, showed how events outside leaders’ direct control could alter the crisis.

6. Verification and implementation

A settlement required dismantling and removing the missiles, monitoring compliance, and resolving disputes over other weapons. Verification had to be credible without creating further confrontation.

7. International and regional diplomacy

The United Nations and the Organization of American States offered forums for legitimacy and mediation. Delegates should consider how multilateral diplomacy could support, rather than obstruct, urgent bilateral communication.

Major Stakeholders

United States government

President John F. Kennedy, the ExComm advisers, the military, and diplomatic officials.

Soviet Union

Nikita Khrushchev and Soviet political, military, and diplomatic officials.

Cuba

Fidel Castro and the Cuban government, whose security and sovereignty were directly affected.

United Nations

Secretary-General U Thant and the UN framework offered channels for de-escalation and inspection proposals.

Organization of American States (OAS)

Provided regional diplomatic support for the U.S. quarantine.

NATO allies

European allies considered the effects on alliance cohesion and the broader Berlin crisis.

Turkey and Italy

Hosted U.S. Jupiter missiles, which formed part of the strategic context and later negotiations.

Military commanders and intelligence services

Provided assessments but also operated in situations where incidents could escalate beyond political control.

Past International Actions and Frameworks

Direct correspondence between Kennedy and Khrushchev (October 1962)

Messages helped clarify possible terms for ending the crisis.

U.S. naval quarantine (announced 22 October 1962)

Applied pressure while allowing time for negotiation.

UN Secretary-General U Thant's diplomatic efforts

The UN offered a channel for proposals and efforts to reduce tensions.

Public Soviet commitment (28 October 1962)
Khrushchev announced that Soviet missiles would be dismantled and removed from Cuba.

U.S. non-invasion assurance
The United States publicly committed not to invade Cuba, subject to the context of the settlement.

Secret understanding on Jupiter missiles
The United States indicated it would remove missiles from Turkey; their removal occurred later and was not part of the public settlement.

Washington–Moscow hotline (1963)
A direct communications link was established after the crisis to improve communication during future emergencies.

Limited Test Ban Treaty (1963)
The crisis contributed to a broader recognition of the dangers of nuclear confrontation and helped create momentum for arms-control efforts.

Timeline

DATE	DEVELOPMENT
1959	Fidel Castro's revolution succeeds in Cuba; relations with the United States deteriorate.
April 1961	The Bay of Pigs invasion fails.
Summer 1962	The Soviet Union and Cuba reach a secret agreement on missile deployments.
14–16 October 1962	U.S. reconnaissance photographs reveal missile sites; Kennedy is briefed.
22 October 1962	Kennedy announces a naval quarantine.
24 October 1962	The quarantine takes effect; ships approach the interception line and the crisis remains tense.
26 October 1962	A Soviet message proposes a possible settlement involving a non-invasion assurance.
27 October 1962	The crisis intensifies; a U.S. U-2 is shot down over Cuba and messages concerning Turkey complicate negotiations.
28 October 1962	Khrushchev announces the removal of Soviet missiles from Cuba.
20 November 1962	The United States ends the quarantine after further arrangements concerning Soviet bombers.
1963	The Washington–Moscow hotline is established and the Limited Test Ban Treaty is signed.

Key Questions a Resolution Must Answer

1. What combination of public pressure and private diplomacy offers the best chance of de-escalation?
2. How can a settlement address U.S., Soviet, and Cuban security concerns without rewarding coercion?
3. Should the United Nations or the OAS play a direct mediation or verification role, and how?
4. What guarantees and verification mechanisms would make missile removal credible?
5. How can leaders prevent an isolated military incident from triggering nuclear escalation?
6. What concessions can be made privately, and how should they be communicated to allies and domestic audiences?

Bibliography and Further Reading

Use these official and institutional sources as starting points, and check the latest documents before citing statistics or claiming that a policy is current.

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